

FOR TEACHERS AND ADMINISTRATORS

COMPLETE SCIENCE FAIR SETUP GUIDE

Everything your school needs to launch a science fair.

Most schools that do not run a science fair are not held back by money. They are held back because no one has been handed a clear plan. This guide is that plan, written for a teacher or administrator who has never organised one. You do not need a science background.



\$300

typical first-year
cost

5 to 8h

per month for the
coordinator

12 mo

from zero to awards
day

Free

FairGame support,
always

START HERE

Work through the twelve sections in order during your first year. After that, treat this as a reference you return to each season.

The pages that follow walk you through planning and running a science fair. You do not need a science background. You need a willingness to get organised, a small team to share the work, and the steps laid out here. FairGame provides the rest at no cost.

HOW FAIRGAME WORKS ALONGSIDE YOU

FairGame meets every school where it is. When you reach out, we talk through your situation, meet with your principal or team if that helps, and set everything up together. Schools usually start in one of three ways.

PROGRAMME	WHO IT FITS	WHAT WE DO
Club Launch	Fewer than ten interested students	Help form a student club and pair it with a local ambassador
Full Fair Program	Ready to run a complete fair	Supply resources, coordinate judges, handle registration, support the coordinating teacher
Individual Mentorship	Students at schools without a fair yet	Match each student with an online mentor and guide them through registration

A NOTE ON USING THIS GUIDE

Numbers and timelines here describe a typical school fair. Your costs, calendar, and format will vary with your size and goals. Read the sections that fit your situation first, then fill in the rest as your programme grows.

WHAT IS INSIDE

1 Getting Administrator Buy-In

Making the case to your principal or board

2 Forming a Science Fair Committee

Sharing the work across three to five people

3 Setting a 12-Month Timeline

A month-by-month path to fair day

4 Choosing Your Format

School-only, district, multi-school, or virtual

5 Registration and the Competition Pathway

Affiliate fairs, ProjectBoard, and the road to ISEF

6 Recruiting Judges

How many you need and where to find them

7 Student Participation and Requirements

Required or optional, grade levels, accommodations

8 Finding Funding

Budgets, sponsors, and small grants

9 Logistics and Venue

Space, tables, safety, and accessibility

10 Supporting Students Through Projects

From topic choice to display board

11 Day-of-Event Checklist

Setup, judging, awards, cleanup

12 Post-Event Follow-Up

Recognition, thank-yous, and next year

APPENDICES

A Frequently Asked Questions

B Resource Index: every editable template and where to find it

1 GETTING ADMINISTRATOR BUY-IN

The most common reason a school has no science fair is not the budget. It is that no one has made a clear, short case to administration.

A one-page proposal that answers the three questions every administrator asks, namely what it costs, how much teacher time it takes, and what students gain, earns a yes more often than any other approach. Keep it brief and specific.

THE CASE TO MAKE

Science fairs build research habits, critical thinking, and presentation confidence that line up with state academic standards. A fair also gives your school something visible to celebrate, opens partnerships with local colleges and employers, and creates scholarship and competition pathways for students who would not otherwise reach them.

ANSWERING THE THREE COMMON OBJECTIONS

CONCERN	HOW TO ANSWER IT
Cost	A school fair runs about \$300 to \$1,500. Local sponsors often cover most of that. Section 8 lays out the full budget and funding sources.
Teacher time	Roughly 5 to 8 hours per month with a committee. FairGame handles judge recruitment, fair registration, and student support, which removes much of the load.
Logistics	A gym or cafeteria is enough. Section 11 gives you a complete day-of checklist so nothing is left to chance.

FAIRGAME TIP

Ask for a fifteen-minute meeting rather than sending the proposal cold. Bring the one-page proposal, a sample timeline, and one or two success stories. Administrators say yes faster when they can ask questions in the room.

WHAT FAIRGAME PROVIDES

A ready-to-send Administrator Proposal template, plus a schools one-pager you can leave behind after the meeting. Both are editable and listed in Appendix B.

2 FORMING A SCIENCE FAIR COMMITTEE

You do not have to run a science fair alone. A committee of three to five people splits the work into manageable pieces.

ROLE	WHAT THEY OWN	TIME IN THE ACTIVE PHASE
Fair Coordinator	Overall lead, usually the proposing teacher. Owns the timeline and talks to the affiliate fair and to FairGame.	5 to 8 hours per month
Judge Coordinator	Recruits and manages judges, and sends them their training materials and assignments.	2 to 3 hours per month
Student Support Lead	Runs workshop sessions and answers student questions as projects develop.	2 to 3 hours per month
Logistics Lead	Manages the venue, tables, signage, and check-in on the day.	2 to 3 hours per month
Communications	Sends parent letters, promotes the fair, and posts updates for the school community.	2 to 3 hours per month

TIME COMMITMENT

Plan for about 5 to 8 hours per month for the coordinator, and 2 to 3 hours per month for other members during the active phase, which falls in months 7 through 12 of the timeline. FairGame support reduces this load noticeably.

RECRUITING TIP

Recruit your committee in the same week you get administrator approval, while interest is high. A short staff email that names the five roles and their hours lets colleagues pick the piece that fits their schedule.

3

SETTING A 12-MONTH TIMELINE

This timeline assumes your fair happens in month twelve. Adjust the start date to your school calendar.

WHEN	PHASE	WHAT HAPPENS
Months 1 to 2	Approval and setup	Submit the administrator proposal, form your committee, set the fair date, and notify your affiliate fair.
Months 3 to 4	Planning	Choose your format, reserve the venue, draft the budget, and begin sponsor outreach.
Months 5 to 6	Recruitment	Send judge invitations, register with ProjectBoard, announce the fair to students and families, and collect permission slips.
Months 7 to 9	Student support	Hold topic selection workshops and check on project progress each month.
Months 10 to 11	Final prep	Finalise judge assignments, order trophies and signage, confirm logistics, and send parent communication.
Month 12	Fair and follow-up	Run fair day, hold the awards ceremony, record advancing students, and send the post-event survey.

BUILD BACKWARD, NOT FORWARD

Find your affiliate fair's registration deadline first, then count back twelve months. Building forward from the first day of school is the most common planning mistake, and it is the one that pushes data collection into January.

WHAT FAIRGAME PROVIDES

A printable month-by-month 12-Month Fair Timeline Checklist as an editable spreadsheet, with owner and target date columns. Pin it in your committee workroom so everyone tracks the same dates.

4

CHOOSING YOUR FORMAT

Four formats work at school level. Pick the smallest one you can run well, then grow.

FORMAT	BEST FOR	WHAT TO KNOW
School-only	A first year, or a school building interest	Delivers real value on its own. Students develop research skills and confidence without any external competition.
Affiliate-linked	Schools ready to send students onward	Register with your state affiliate so qualifying students can advance to district and state competition.
Multi-school	Small schools nearby with few students each	Share judges, venue, and cost across schools. Solves the problem of too few projects to fill a fair.
Virtual	Rural schools, or where travel is the barrier	ProjectBoard supports virtual submission and judging without extra tools, and removes travel entirely.

START WHERE YOU CAN

A school-only fair with no external competition is a complete, worthwhile event. Many teachers run internal fairs for years before registering with a state affiliate. Expanding later is easy; starting at all is the hard part.

5 REGISTRATION AND THE COMPETITION PATHWAY

In Ohio, the Ohio Academy of Science runs the competitive pathway, and every deliverable in the FairGame curriculum maps to its requirements.

THE PATHWAY

- 1 School fair. Your own event, on your own terms and calendar.
- 2 District or regional fair. Run by an OAS district, typically December through February.
- 3 State Science Day. Held annually in Columbus.
- 4 ISEF. The international fair, reached through state-level qualification.

REGISTRATION

OAS registration is completed through ProjectBoard at oas.projectboard.net. Allow 45 minutes to walk through registration for your school the first time. ProjectBoard also enforces safety rules during registration, which is the simplest way to confirm a student project complies before fair day.

WHAT YOU NEED	WHERE IT COMES FROM
Affiliate fair contact	Your OAS district. FairGame can identify yours.
Student roster with project titles	Your own records, confirmed before the deadline
Safety documentation	Supplied by FairGame when you register
Approval forms for human or animal subjects	Link to the current OAS forms rather than recreating them

WHAT FAIRGAME PROVIDES

Registration support, current safety documentation, and help identifying your OAS district and its deadlines.

6

RECRUITING JUDGES

Aim for one judge per five to eight projects. Judges are the part of a fair schools worry about most, and the part FairGame most reliably solves.

WHERE JUDGES COME FROM

- Local colleges and universities. Contact department chairs directly.
- Local employers with engineering, healthcare, laboratory, or technical staff.
- Retired scientists, engineers, nurses, and teachers in your community.
- Parents and alumni with STEM backgrounds.
- FairGame's judge network, which exists precisely so you do not have to build one.

WHAT JUDGES NEED FROM YOU

- The rubric and their category assignments a few days ahead, not on the morning.
- Clear arrival time, parking details, and a contact number.
- A short briefing on the day, about thirty minutes.
- A quiet space to score and deliberate.

NO PHD REQUIRED

A bachelor's degree or equivalent professional experience is enough. Judges come from industry, healthcare, education, trades, and research. Saying this in your invitation roughly doubles the response rate.

WHAT FAIRGAME PROVIDES

Judge recruitment through our network, plus a complete Judge Packet: welcome guide, weighted rubric with score sheet, sample interview questions, code of conduct, FAQ, and per-project judging cards.

7 STUDENT PARTICIPATION AND REQUIREMENTS

Decide early whether participation is required or optional, and be consistent about it.

DECISION	CONSIDERATIONS
Required for a grade level	Produces the fullest fair and reaches students who would never volunteer. Needs the most in-class support time.
Optional	Lower teacher load, and students who opt in are motivated. Risks reaching only students who already had access.
Required in one class, optional elsewhere	A practical middle path. Often the strongest first-year choice.

GRADE LEVELS

The FairGame curriculum covers Grades 5 to 8 across three bands: Grades 5 to 6 use guided experiments completed entirely in class, Grade 7 opens topic choice with most work still in class, and Grade 8 runs student-led on a milestone schedule. High school students can compete individually and are also eligible for the Student Ambassador programme.

ACCOMMODATIONS

- Apply existing IEP and 504 accommodations directly to project milestones and presentation.
- Allow the journal to be kept in a student's first language, with the final report in English.
- Keep all work at school where home support is limited. Provide every material from the classroom supply.
- Allow presentation to one adult rather than a group where anxiety is documented.

PERMISSION SLIPS

Collect a signed permission slip from every participant, including photo consent. An editable Parent Letter and Permission Slip is listed in Appendix B.

8 FINDING FUNDING

Most school science fairs can be funded through a mix of a small school budget line, local business sponsorship, and donated refreshments.

LINE ITEM	TYPICAL RANGE	NOTES
Trophies and ribbons	\$100 to \$400	The main cost driver for most fairs
Printed materials and signage	\$50 to \$200	Programmes, category signs, wayfinding
Display board supplies	\$100 to \$300	For students who need boards provided
Refreshments	\$0 to \$200	Often donated by the PTO or a local business
State affiliate registration	Varies	Confirm current fees with your affiliate fair
Total	\$300 to \$2,000	A school-only fair with printed signs costs far less

FUNDING SOURCES TO PURSUE

- A school budget line item, requested at \$500 to \$1,000 as a new programme.
- PTO or PTA sponsorship.
- Local business sponsorships, using the sponsorship request letter.
- Community foundation STEM education grants.
- State Farm Youth Advisory Board grants.
- Amazon Future Engineer.

WHAT FAIRGAME PROVIDES

Help connecting your school with local sponsors, an editable Sponsorship Request Letter, and a School Budget Template with the totals already formulated.

9 LOGISTICS AND VENUE

A gym or cafeteria is enough. What matters is that tables are numbered, signage is posted, and someone owns each area.

ELEMENT	WHAT TO PLAN FOR
Space	One table per project, plus circulation room for judges and families. A gym or cafeteria suits most fairs.
Tables	Numbered and matched to a project map, so a judge can find project 14 without asking.
Power	Confirm outlet locations early. Some projects need power; most do not.
Safety	No open flame, no hazardous chemicals, no live animals, no unshielded batteries on display.
Accessibility	Confirm the entrance, judging area, refreshments, and awards area are all wheelchair accessible.
Emergency	Keep an emergency contact list on hand throughout the event.

ASSIGN PHOTOGRAPHY TO ONE PERSON

Good photos of students at their boards become your annual report images, your sponsor thank-yous, and your recruitment material for next year. Check photo consent on permission slips first.

10 SUPPORTING STUDENTS THROUGH PROJECTS

Student support concentrates in months 7 through 9. The structure matters more than the science expertise.

STAGE	WHAT STUDENTS NEED FROM YOU
Topic choice	Permission to pick something ordinary. Most students overreach, then stall.
Background research	A single credible source, recorded properly, is enough to start.
Hypothesis	The if, then, because pattern, modelled out loud once.
Design approval	A conversation before they begin. This is where you catch flawed designs cheaply.
Data collection	Monthly progress checks and a reminder that recording as you go is the whole job.
Analysis	Help with averages and choosing the right graph. Most students need this.
Board and paper	A template. Blank-page paralysis is the biggest cause of unfinished projects.
Presentation	One practice round with you playing judge.

THE ONE THING TO INSIST ON

Journals collected every three weeks. Students who keep a genuine dated record cannot fabricate their process, and the journal is what teachers and judges rely on.

WHAT FAIRGAME PROVIDES

A complete Student Toolkit, a Teacher Handbook with four stage-based grading rubrics, lesson plan templates, and the full Grades 5 to 8 curriculum mapped to Ohio Learning Standards and CCSS.

DAY-OF-EVENT CHECKLIST

Print one copy per committee member. Times assume a fair that opens to judging mid-morning.

TWO HOURS BEFORE, SETUP

- ☐ Tables arranged, numbered, and matched to the project map
- ☐ Check-in table set with project numbers, name tags, and a master roster
- ☐ Judge packets laid out, with rubrics and category lists
- ☐ Signage posted at entrance, categories, judging room, and awards area
- ☐ Refreshments set; power and audio-visual equipment tested

ONE HOUR BEFORE, ARRIVALS

- ☐ Students checked in and placed at their tables
- ☐ Judges welcomed, briefed, and given assignments
- ☐ Quiet deliberation space confirmed and stocked with score sheets

DURING JUDGING

- ☐ Judges circulating on schedule; runner available for questions
- ☐ Photography underway across categories
- ☐ Score sheets collected as each judge finishes

AWARDS AND CLOSE

- ☐ Scores tallied and awards confirmed
- ☐ Awards ceremony held; qualifying students recorded for advancement
- ☐ Cleanup assignments distributed; venue restored
- ☐ Emergency contact list kept on hand throughout

POST-EVENT FOLLOW-UP

What you do in the week after the fair decides how easy next year is.

IN THE FIRST WEEK

- Run the post-event survey for students, judges, and families. Short surveys get more responses.
- Hold a short committee debrief. Write down what worked and what to change while memories are clear.
- Send thank-you notes to judges, sponsors, and volunteers. Certificates are provided as mail-merge templates.
- Record which students qualified to advance, and their deadlines.

IN THE FIRST MONTH

- Share photos with families and on school channels, checking photo consent first.
- Send sponsors a short note with a photo and a number. This is what makes them say yes again.
- Set next year's date while goodwill is high.
- Ask any judge who enjoyed it to come back, and to bring a colleague.

THE HIGHEST-RETURN FIVE MINUTES

Ask every judge whether they would judge again, and whether they know a colleague who might. Judge recruitment for next year is easiest on the day someone has just enjoyed it.

WHAT FAIRGAME PROVIDES

Post-Event Survey template, five mail-merge certificate templates with a name list spreadsheet, and continuing support for next year's fair.

FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS

How much does a school science fair actually cost?

Most first-year school fairs run \$300 to \$1,500. Trophies, signage, and printed materials are the main costs. Refreshments are often donated by the PTO or a local business. FairGame can connect you with local sponsors to offset what remains.

How much time does it take for the coordinating teacher?

About 5 to 8 hours per month during the active phase in months 7 through 11, and roughly 15 to 20 hours in the month of the event. With a committee, that load spreads across three to five people, and FairGame support reduces it further.

What if we do not have any STEM teachers?

A science fair can be organised by any motivated teacher with support from FairGame. We provide the content knowledge through our resources, and you provide the organisational energy. Many successful fairs are coordinated by teachers outside the sciences.

Can we run a virtual science fair?

Yes. ProjectBoard fully supports virtual judging and project submission, and we can help you set up a fully virtual fair if in-person logistics are a barrier. Virtual fairs work especially well for rural schools where bringing judges in person is difficult.

Do students need to advance to district to make the fair worthwhile?

Not at all. A school-only fair delivers real value. Students develop research skills, practise presenting in public, and build confidence. Many teachers run internal fairs for years before registering with a state affiliate.

How do we handle safety concerns with student projects?

Your state affiliate fair has clear safety guidelines, including rules for hazardous materials, animals, human subjects, and controlled substances. ProjectBoard enforces these during registration, and FairGame supplies the current safety documentation when you register.

RESOURCE INDEX

Every template referenced in this guide exists as a separate editable file, so you can fill it in rather than retype it.

Earlier editions of this guide printed these templates as appendices. They are now maintained as individual files, which means a change to a template reaches you without the guide being reissued. Ask FairGame for the current School Coordinator Kit, or download it from the teacher portal.

SCHOOL COORDINATOR KIT

TEMPLATE	FORMAT	WHERE IT IS USED
Administrator Proposal	Word	Section 1
Committee Job Descriptions	Word	Section 2
12-Month Fair Timeline Checklist	Excel	Section 3
Judge Invitation Email	Word	Section 6
Parent Letter and Permission Slip	Word	Section 7
Sponsorship Request Letter	Word	Section 8
School Budget Template	Excel	Section 8
Day-of-Event Checklist	PDF	Section 11
Post-Event Survey	Word	Section 12

ALSO AVAILABLE AT NO COST

SET	WHAT IS IN IT
Judge Packet	Welcome guide, weighted rubric and score sheet, sample interview questions, code of conduct, FAQ, judging cards
Teacher Resources	Teacher handbook, implementation guide, lesson plan templates, four stage-based grading rubrics, differentiation guide, materials list
Curriculum Modules	Grades 5 to 6, Grade 7, and Grade 8 modules, plus a standards alignment map for OLS 2018 and CCSS
Student Toolkit	Science journal, lab notebook, hypothesis worksheet, experimental design planner, display board template, research paper template, and more
Classroom Set	Scientific method and lab safety posters, variables anchor chart, wonder wall, vocabulary word wall cards, kickoff decks, progress tracker
Certificates and Event Materials	Five mail-merge certificates, name tags, table tent cards, directional signage, welcome sign